

Pink Mosque

A 19th-century mosque that, through its use of light and color, is among the most stunning examples of Islamic art in the world



W. Asia

The Nasir al-Mulk Mosque is also known as the Pink Mosque, the Mosque of Colors, and the Rainbow Mosque. It was built in Shiraz, Iran, on the orders of Mirza Hasan 'Ali Nasir al-Mulk, a member of the Qajar dynasty, which ruled Persia (Iran) from 1779 to 1925. Begun in 1876, the mosque was completed by 1888. Its layout is traditional for Islamic, and specifically Persian, architecture—two prayer halls face one another across a courtyard and are joined by a vaulted hall, known as an *iwan*, topped by two low minarets. The courtyard has a rectangular pool, which both cools the air and symbolizes ritual purification.

Inner beauty

The mosque's external decoration of intricately patterned pink, yellow, and blue ceramic tiles gives only a hint of the beauty of its interior. Determined to create a place

of worship that reflected the relationship between Heaven and Earth, the mosque's two designers—Mohammad Hasan-e-Memar and Mohammad Reza Kashi-Saz-e-Sirazi—turned the interior into a space filled with jewel-like light and color. As the morning Sun hits the stained-glass facade of the winter prayer hall, a kaleidoscope of color spills onto its inner walls, which are covered from floor to ceiling in tiled, stuccoed, and painted designs. The three-dimensional and highly decorated *muqarnas* (see panel, below) and *panj kaseh-l* (the "five concave shapes") that adorn the ceiling domes create patterns of light and shade that add to the mosque's vibrant beauty. This ebullient use of color is balanced by the simplicity of the building itself and the expert use of symmetry, repetitions, and geometry, typical of Islamic architecture, so that the mosque never feels overwhelming but remains a joyful and peaceful place.

The extensive use of **glazed, rose-colored tiles** gave the **mosque its name**



△ ISLAMIC SYMMETRY

The ritual pool in the courtyard of the Pink Mosque leads to the *iwan* with clearly visible *muqarnas*. The *iwan* links the prayer halls to the left and right.

◁ KALEIDOSCOPIC INTERIORS

Light floods through the mosque's stained-glass windows, casting colorful patterns on the woven carpets and the carved, tiled interior of the prayer hall.

MUQARNAS

The Pink Mosque features many examples of *muqarnas*, three-dimensional tiers of carved and molded stucco cells, pendants, and brackets. *Muqarnas* are used to decorate vaults, cornices, and other parts of buildings throughout the Islamic world. Seen from below, light plays over the smooth, sculpted, but regularly composed surface to dazzling effect.

